Digesting the Subexponential Algorithm for #k-SAT

Eitan Porat

Working draft of November 12, 2026. This note is continually being revised; the latest version is at https://eitanporat.github.io/papers/ksat.pdf.

Abstract

The Anthropic manuscript [4] gives, for every $\delta > 0$, an algorithm that counts the satisfying assignments of a k-CNF formula on n variables in time $O(2^{\delta n})$, and so refutes the Exponential Time Hypothesis and its counting version. This note is an exposition of that algorithm, prepared with the aid of AI; it simplifies the proof and aims to make it accessible to a general audience. The algorithm divides the clauses into groups, and its cost is set by the inter-group edges, the variables that two groups share. Arranging the groups in a square grid and merging the groups of each row removes the variables shared within a row, but most shared variables join groups in different rows and different columns, and no merge removes them. The key tool is an algebraic identity that rewrites two such crossing connections as connections within columns minus connections within rows. Combined with a low-rank decomposition that comes from Gram–Schmidt orthogonalization, it lets every level of a recursive merge remove a constant fraction of the shared variables.

Contents

1 Introduction **2**

2 Preliminaries **3**

3 Merging Rows and Columns **6**

4 Turning Diagonals into Row and Column Edges **8**

5 Full Crossings **11**

6 The Algorithm **13**

A Proof of the Sparsification Lemma **15**

B The Balancing Lemma 20

1 Introduction

The k-SAT problem asks whether a k-CNF formula on n variables has a satisfying assignment, and its counting version, #k-SAT, asks for the number of satisfying assignments. Trying all 2^n assignments solves both. For k-SAT, a long line of work gives algorithms that run in time c_k^n for a constant $c_k < 2$, among them the branching algorithm of Monien and Speckenmeyer [13], the random walk of Schöning [16], and the PPSZ algorithm of Paturi, Pudlák, Saks and Zane [14] with the refined analysis of Hertli [8]. In all of them c_k tends to 2 as k grows. For counting, Dubois [7] gave an algorithm faster than 2^n for every fixed k, and Dahllöf, Jonsson and Wahlström [5] gave faster ones for #2-SAT and #3-SAT. A different approach is dynamic programming over a tree decomposition of the formula, which counts the satisfying assignments in time exponential only in the treewidth [15]. The algorithm in this note is closer to this second approach: it also sums over a decomposition of the formula into parts, and its cost is set by the variables that the parts share.

Impagliazzo and Paturi [9] conjectured that the base cannot be brought down to 1:

Exponential Time Hypothesis (ETH) (Impagliazzo and Paturi [9])**.** *There is a constant $c > 0$ such that no algorithm solves 3-SAT on n variables in time 2^{cn}.*

The Strong Exponential Time Hypothesis [9, 3] conjectures in addition that c_k must tend to 2. Together with the sparsification lemma of Impagliazzo, Paturi and Zane [10], ETH became the standard assumption behind lower bounds for exact and parameterized algorithms; see the survey of Lokshtanov, Marx and Saurabh [11]. Dell, Husfeldt, Marx, Taslaman and Wahlén [6] introduced the counting version, #ETH, which makes the same claim for #3-SAT, and used it to prove lower bounds for the permanent and the Tutte polynomial.

The Anthropic manuscript [4] shows that both hypotheses are false:

Theorem 1 ([4])**.** *For every k and every $\delta > 0$ there is an algorithm that counts the satisfying assignments of a k-CNF formula on n variables in time $O_{k,\delta}(2^{\delta n})$, that is, at most $c(k,\delta)\cdot 2^{\delta n}$ for a number $c(k,\delta)$ that depends only on k and δ.*

In particular, the algorithm solves k-SAT in the same time. This note is an exposition of the proof, prepared with the aid of AI. It simplifies parts of the argument and aims to be compact and accessible to a general audience, and Appendix A gives a self-contained proof of the sparsification lemma in the form that counting needs.

1.1 Overview of the Algorithm

Write the number of satisfying assignments as a sum, over all assignments, of a product with one factor for each clause. By the sparsification lemma we may assume that the formula has $m = O_{k,\delta}(n)$ clauses. We divide the clauses into G groups, for a large constant G, so that every variable either lies inside one group or is *shared* by two groups. Summing out the variables inside the groups leaves a sum over the N shared variables of a product with one factor for each group, and computing it directly takes time $2^{N+O_k(n/G)}$. By a theorem of Bollobás and Scott [1], we can choose the groups so that every two of them share about the same number of variables. The rest of the algorithm reduces the exponent N.

We arrange the groups in a $\sqrt{G} \times \sqrt{G}$ grid. Moving the sums over the variables shared inside a row next to the factors of that row is the same as merging the groups of the row into one group, and these variables no longer count towards the exponent. But a merge of the rows, or of the columns, removes only a fraction $O(1/\sqrt{G})$ of the shared variables: almost all pairs of groups lie in different rows and different columns, and the variables they share, which we call *diagonal*, survive every merge.

The main tool is an identity that writes the two diagonals of a rectangle in the grid as a product of two edges inside its columns minus a product of two edges inside its rows. When each diagonal carries t bits, a Gram–Schmidt step and a split by majority write the crossing as a part that costs at most $(2\sqrt{3})^t$ when the rows are merged plus a part that costs at most $(2\sqrt{3})^t$ when the columns are merged, instead of 4^t. Multiplying out over all rectangles gives a constant number of networks. Each is merged in the direction that most of its rectangles prefer and keeps at most $2^{(1-\eta)N}$ values in its outer sum, for a constant $\eta \approx 0.05$. A constant number of such merges brings the exponent below δn.

Organization.

Section 2 covers sparsification and writes the count as a sum over the shared variables of a network of groups. Section 3 introduces the grid and the merges, Section 4 proves the crossing identity and defines the row and column ranks, and Section 5 splits a crossing with many bits. Section 6 puts the pieces together, and Appendix A proves the sparsification lemma.

2 Preliminaries

A **k-CNF formula** on the Boolean variables $x_1, \ldots, x_n$ is an AND of clauses $C_1, \ldots, C_m$, and each clause is an OR of at most k literals: variables x_i or their negations $\neg x_i$. For

example,

$$F = (x_1 \vee \neg x_2 \vee x_3) \wedge (\neg x_1 \vee x_4)$$

is a 3-CNF formula. An assignment $a \in \{0,1\}^n$ **satisfies** F if it makes a literal true in every clause, and we write $Z(F)$ for the number of satisfying assignments. The k**-SAT** problem asks whether $Z(F) > 0$, and its counting version, #k**-SAT**, asks for $Z(F)$ itself. Counting is at least as hard as deciding, so an algorithm for #k-SAT also solves k-SAT.

2.1 Sparsification

We would like to assume that the formula does not have many clauses: $m = O(n)$. The sparsification lemma lets us do this.

Lemma 2 (Sparsification lemma)**.** *For every $k \geq 2$ and every $\varepsilon > 0$ there is a number $M = M(k,\varepsilon)$ such that every k-CNF formula F on n variables can be split, in time $2^{\varepsilon n}\mathrm{poly}_{k,\varepsilon}(n)$, into a list $\mathcal{L}$ of k-CNF formulas on the same variables such that*

(a) $\mathcal{L}$ has at most $2^{\varepsilon n}$ formulas;

(b) every formula in $\mathcal{L}$ has at most Mn clauses;

(c) every assignment that satisfies F satisfies exactly one formula in $\mathcal{L}$, and every assignment that satisfies a formula in $\mathcal{L}$ satisfies F.

In particular, $Z(F) = \sum_{F' \in \mathcal{L}} Z(F')$.

Impagliazzo, Paturi and Zane [10] proved the lemma with "at least one formula" in (c), which is enough for k-SAT, and Calabro, Impagliazzo and Paturi [2] gave a sharper version. Dell et al. [6] proved the form above, in which the formulas in $\mathcal{L}$ have disjoint sets of solutions; this is the form that counting needs. Appendix A gives a self-contained proof.

The reduction.

Fix $\delta > 0$ and apply the lemma with $\varepsilon = \delta/2$; this fixes $M = M(k, \delta/2)$. Suppose that every k-CNF formula with n variables and at most Mn clauses can be counted in time $O_{k,\delta}(2^{\delta n/2})$. Then

$$Z(F) = \sum_{F' \in \mathcal{L}} Z(F'), \qquad |\mathcal{L}| \leq 2^{\delta n/2},$$

takes time $2^{\delta n/2}\,\mathrm{poly}(n) + |\mathcal{L}| \cdot O_{k,\delta}(2^{\delta n/2}) = O_{k,\delta}(2^{\delta n})$. So it is enough to count formulas with at most Mn clauses, and from now on $m \leq Mn$, that is, $m = O_{k,\delta}(n)$.

2.2 Networks of Groups

Let $C_i(a) = 1$ if the assignment a satisfies C_i, and $C_i(a) = 0$ otherwise. Then

$$Z(F) = \sum_{a \in \{0,1\}^n} \prod_{i=1}^{m} C_i(a).$$

If no two clauses share a variable, the sum factors: $Z(F) = \prod_i \bigl(2^{|C_i|} - 1\bigr)$, times 2 for each variable in no clause. All the difficulty comes from the shared variables.

Divide the clauses into groups $g = 1, \ldots, G$. Give each variable one copy for each two consecutive clauses that contain it, with a check that the copies agree, and from now on call these copies the variables. So each variable is one bit, and it is either

- **inside** one group, or
- **shared** by exactly two groups.

Summing the inside variables first gives

$$Z(F) = \sum_{\text{shared variables}} \prod_{g=1}^{G} Z_g,$$

where Z_g counts the assignments of the variables inside group g that satisfy group g, for the given values of the shared variables. We call the groups, with their functions Z_g and the shared variables, a **network** $\mathcal{N}$; its value $Z(\mathcal{N})$ is the sum above.

The cost of a grouping.

Let N be the number of shared variables. For each of their 2^N values we compute the G numbers Z_g by brute force and multiply them. A group has $O_k(n/G)$ variables inside it, and G is a constant (Section 6.2), so we get a running time of

$$2^{N + O_k(n/G)}.$$

2.3 Balanced Groups

We can spread the shared variables evenly over the pairs of groups. A theorem of Bollobás and Scott [1, Theorems 4–5] gives, in polynomial time, a grouping in which every group has $m/G \pm O_k(1)$ clauses and every two groups share $t \pm O_k(1)$ variables, where

$$t = \Theta_k\Bigl(\frac{n}{G^2}\Bigr).$$

3 Merging Rows and Columns

3.1 The Grid

Put the G groups in a $\sqrt{G} \times \sqrt{G}$ grid; $g_{r,c}$ is the group in row r and column c, and $Z_{r,c}$ is its count $Z_{g_{r,c}}$. Seen from one group, the other $G-1$ groups are of three kinds (Figure 1).

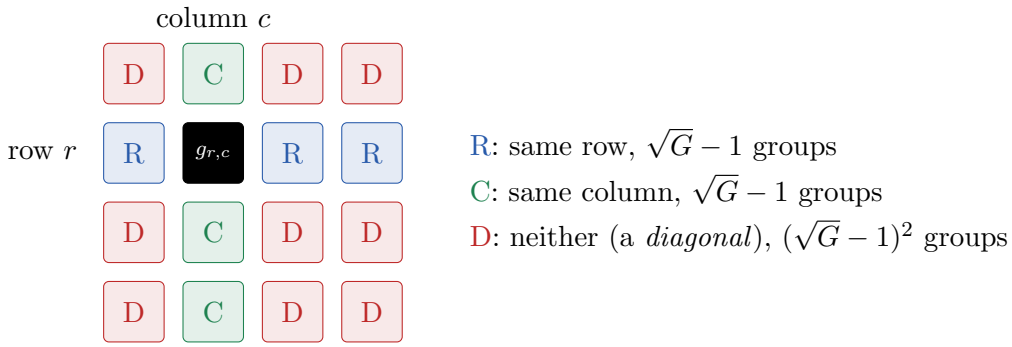


Figure 1: The other groups, seen from the group $g_{r,c}$ in a 4×4 grid.

Every two groups share $t \pm O_k(1)$ variables (Section 2.3), so, up to this $\pm O_k(1)$, the N shared variables divide like the pairs:

kind of pair	number of pairs	fraction of the shared variables
R: same row	$\frac{1}{2}G(\sqrt{G}-1)$	$\frac{1}{\sqrt{G}+1}$
C: same column	$\frac{1}{2}G(\sqrt{G}-1)$	$\frac{1}{\sqrt{G}+1}$
D: diagonal	$\frac{1}{2}G(\sqrt{G}-1)^2$	$\frac{\sqrt{G}-1}{\sqrt{G}+1}$

For large G, almost all shared variables are on diagonals.

3.2 Merging the Rows

Write Z with the shared variables sorted by kind and the product sorted by rows:

$$Z = \sum_{C \text{ variables}} \sum_{D \text{ variables}} \sum_{R \text{ variables}} \prod_{r=1}^{\sqrt{G}} \prod_{c=1}^{\sqrt{G}} Z_{r,c}.$$

An R variable of row r is shared by two groups of row r, so only the factors $Z_{r,1}, \ldots, Z_{r,\sqrt{G}}$ use it. So we can change the order of summation and move its sum inside, next to these

factors:

$$Z = \sum_{C \text{ variables}} \sum_{D \text{ variables}} \prod_{r=1}^{\sqrt{G}} \left[\sum_{R \text{ variables of row } r} \prod_{c=1}^{\sqrt{G}} Z_{r,c} \right].$$

This is equivalent to merging the groups of each row into one group (Figure 2): the bracket of row r is the count of the merged group.

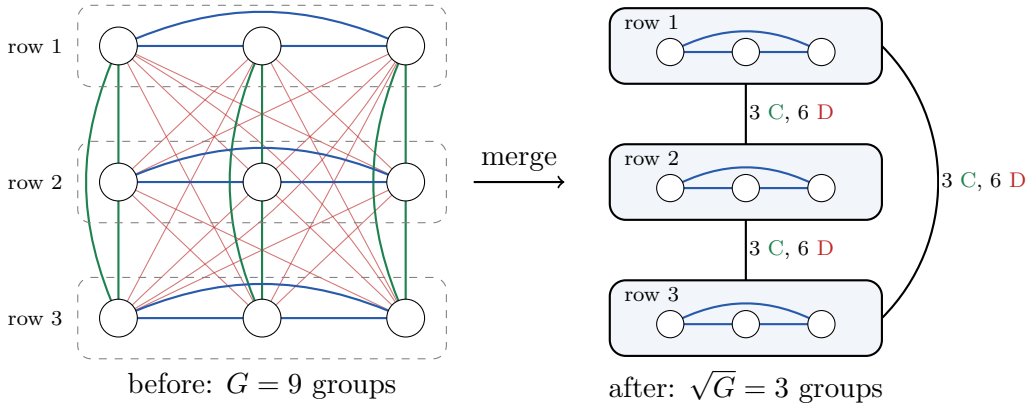


Figure 2: Merging the rows of a 3×3 grid. Left: all 36 pairs of groups, namely 9 R pairs (blue), 9 C pairs (green) and 18 D pairs (red). Right: each row is one new group (a box) that contains its three groups and its 3 R pairs. Every two new groups are joined by 3 C pairs and 6 D pairs; in general, by $\sqrt{G}$ C pairs and $\sqrt{G}(\sqrt{G}-1)$ D pairs.

The run time.

Before the merge, the outer sum runs over all N shared variables. After it, the outer sum runs over the C and D variables only. For each of their values, the $\sqrt{G}$ brackets are computed one after the other, and each bracket runs over the R variables of one row: $1/\sqrt{G}$ of the R variables. With the fractions of the table, and up to the factor $2^{O_k(n/G)}$ of the groups (Section 2.2), the run times are

$$\text{before the merge:} \quad 2^{\left(\frac{1}{\sqrt{G}+1}+\frac{1}{\sqrt{G}+1}+\frac{\sqrt{G}-1}{\sqrt{G}+1}\right)N} = 2^N,$$

$$\text{after the merge:} \quad 2^{\left(\frac{1}{\sqrt{G}+1}+\frac{\sqrt{G}-1}{\sqrt{G}+1}\right)N} \cdot 2^{\frac{1}{\sqrt{G}(\sqrt{G}+1)}N} = 2^{(1-O(1/\sqrt{G}))N}.$$

Example 1. Take the clauses $C_1 = x_1 \vee x_2 \vee x_3$, $C_2 = x_1 \vee x_4 \vee x_5$, $C_3 = x_2 \vee x_4 \vee x_6$ and $C_4 = x_3 \vee x_5 \vee x_6$, so that every two of them share one variable.

Put C_1, C_2 in the top row and C_3, C_4 in the bottom row (Figure 3). The R variables are x_1, x_6, the C variables are x_2, x_5, and the D variables are x_3, x_4.

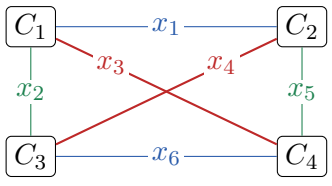


Figure 3: The example as a 2×2 grid.

Moving the sums of the R variables inside merges the rows:

$$Z = \sum_{x_1,\ldots,x_6} C_1C_2C_3C_4 = \sum_{x_2,x_3,x_4,x_5} \Big[\sum_{x_1} C_1C_2\Big]\Big[\sum_{x_6} C_3C_4\Big].$$

A merge of the columns leaves x_1, x_3, x_4, x_6 shared; a merge along the diagonals, $\{C_1, C_4\}$ and $\{C_2, C_3\}$, leaves x_1, x_2, x_5, x_6. Every merge leaves 4 shared variables.

3.3 Why Merges Are Not Enough

A merge improves the exponent only by a fraction $O(1/\sqrt{G})$, because it removes only R variables. Almost all shared variables are D variables, and no merge removes them.

Suppose, *hypothetically*, that each diagonal were an edge inside one row. Then the same merge of the rows would put the D variables inside the brackets, and each row would get only its own share:

$$Z = \sum_{C \text{ variables}} \prod_{r=1}^{\sqrt{G}} \Bigg[\sum_{R \text{ variables of row } r} \; \sum_{D \text{ variables of row } r} \; \prod_{c=1}^{\sqrt{G}} Z_{r,c} \Bigg].$$

Each row gets $1/\sqrt{G}$ of the D variables, so the run time drops from $2^{(1-O(1/\sqrt{G}))N}$ to

$$2^{\frac{1}{\sqrt{G}+1}N} \cdot 2^{(\frac{1}{\sqrt{G}(\sqrt{G}+1)}+\frac{\sqrt{G}-1}{\sqrt{G}(\sqrt{G}+1)})N} = 2^{O(N/\sqrt{G})}.$$

The case of a merge of the columns is the same. So next we turn the diagonal edges into row and column edges.

4 Turning Diagonals into Row and Column Edges

Take two rows $r \neq r'$ and two columns $c \neq c'$. The four groups $g_{r,c}, g_{r,c'}, g_{r',c}, g_{r',c'}$ form a **rectangle**, and its two diagonals, $g_{r,c}$–$g_{r',c'}$ and $g_{r,c'}$–$g_{r',c}$, are D pairs that cross. Every D pair is a diagonal of exactly one rectangle, so we can remove the D variables one rectangle at a time. In this section each diagonal carries one bit; Section 5 does the full crossing.

4.1 Copies at the Ends of the Diagonals

We want to separate the two ends of each diagonal. So we replace the variable of a diagonal by two new variables, one at each end, and add a new factor that forces them to be equal, the **equality condition**:

- first diagonal: x at $g_{r,c}$ and v at $g_{r',c'}$, with the condition $[x = v]$;
- second diagonal: y at $g_{r,c'}$ and u at $g_{r',c}$, with the condition $[y = u]$.

Together they give the factor

$$q = [x = v] \cdot [y = u].$$

Each condition is an edge between two groups in different rows and different columns (Figure 4), so no merge removes it.

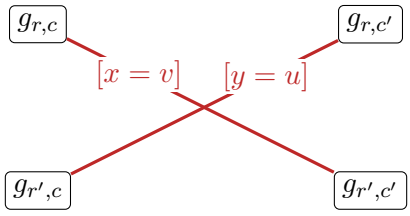


Figure 4: The two diagonals of a rectangle, as the edges $[x = v]$ and $[y = u]$.

4.2 The Crossing Identity

The product of the two diagonals is a difference of two products of edges (Figure 5):

$$\underbrace{[x = v] \cdot [y = u]}_{\text{two diagonal edges}} = \underbrace{[x = u] \cdot [y = v]}_{L\text{: two column edges}} - \underbrace{(y - x) \cdot (v - u)}_{T\text{: two row edges}}.$$

The factor $[x = u]$ joins $g_{r,c}$ and $g_{r',c}$, and $[y = v]$ joins $g_{r,c'}$ and $g_{r',c'}$: two edges inside the columns c and c'. The factor $(y - x)$ joins $g_{r,c}$ and $g_{r,c'}$, and $(v - u)$ joins $g_{r',c}$ and $g_{r',c'}$: two edges inside the rows r and r'. We call this identity the **crossing identity**.

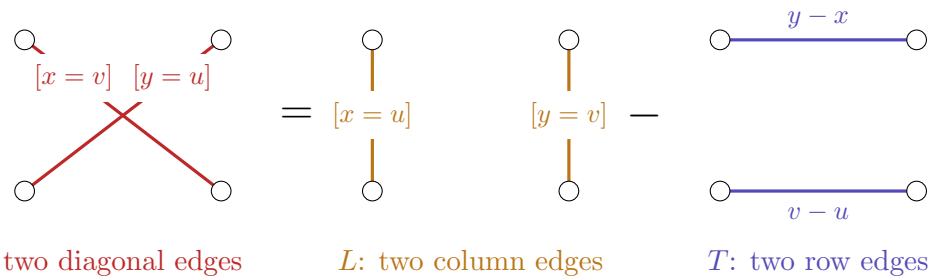


Figure 5: Two diagonal edges equal two column edges minus two row edges. The corners are $g_{r,c}, g_{r,c'}$ (top) and $g_{r',c}, g_{r',c'}$ (bottom).

Put into the sum, the crossing identity splits the value of the network in two: $Z(\mathcal{N}) = Z(\mathcal{N}_L) - Z(\mathcal{N}_T)$, where $\mathcal{N}_L$ has the two column edges and is merged by columns, and $\mathcal{N}_T$ has the two row edges and is merged by rows.

4.3 Row Rank and Column Rank

Each factor of a rectangle, such as L, T or the crossing $[x = v]\,[y = u]$, is a function $\varphi(x, y, u, v)$ of its four copies, and the copies sit at the corners of the rectangle:

	column c	column c'
row r	x	y
row r'	u	v

The copies can be single bits or strings of bits. We can write φ as a sum of products in two ways: products of a function of the top row and a function of the bottom row, or products of a function of the left column and a function of the right column.

- The **row rank** of φ is the smallest s such that

$$\varphi = \sum_{i=1}^{s} f_i(x, y)\, h_i(u, v) \qquad (\text{top} \cdot \text{bottom}).$$

- The **column rank** of φ is the smallest s such that

$$\varphi = \sum_{i=1}^{s} f_i(x, u)\, h_i(y, v) \qquad (\text{left} \cdot \text{right}).$$

Intuitively, the ranks are the extra cost of a factor when we merge. With the rows merged, each of the s products splits between the two rows, so a factor of row rank s multiplies the outer sum by s. With the columns merged, the same holds for the column rank.

Computing the ranks.

A sum of s products $f_i(x, y)\, h_i(u, v)$ is a matrix of rank at most s, with rows (x, y) and columns (u, v), and every matrix of rank s is such a sum. So

- the row rank of φ is the rank of its matrix with rows (x, y) and columns (u, v);
- the column rank of φ is the rank of its matrix with rows (x, u) and columns (y, v).

One bit. Order the rows and the columns as $00, 01, 10, 11$, and let

$$\beta(x, y) = y - x = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \\ -1 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}, \qquad \gamma(x, u) = [x = u] = \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \\ 0 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Then the matrices of $L = [x = u]\,[y = v]$ and $T = (y - x)(v - u)$ are

	rows (x, y), columns (u, v)	rows (x, u), columns (y, v)
L	$I = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ (rank 4)	$\gamma\gamma^{\mathsf{T}} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ (rank 1)
T	$\beta\beta^{\mathsf{T}} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ (rank 1)	$P = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & -1 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 & 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ (rank 4)

5 Full Crossings

Every two groups share $t = \Theta_k(n/G^2)$ variables (Section 2.3), so each diagonal of a rectangle carries t bits. The copies are $x, y, u, v \in \{0,1\}^t$, and the crossing identity of Section 4 applies to each bit j:

$$q = [x = v]\,[y = u] = \prod_{j=1}^{t} [x_j = v_j]\,[y_j = u_j] = \prod_{j=1}^{t} (L_j - T_j).$$

5.1 Mixed Terms

A merge puts every group into exactly one new group: $g_{r,c}$ goes with its row or with its column, not with both: both together would put all G groups into one group, with an inside cost of $2^{\Theta(n)}$. So a network is merged either by rows or by columns, never partly by each.

Multiplying out q gives one term for each set J of the bits that take T:

$$q = \sum_{J \subseteq \{1,\dots,t\}} (-1)^{|J|}\, T_J\, L_{\bar{J}}, \qquad T_J = \prod_{j \in J} T_j, \quad L_{\bar{J}} = \prod_{j \notin J} L_j.$$

Since ranks multiply over the bits, the term of J has row rank $4^{t-|J|}$ and column rank $4^{|J|}$. A pure term is cheap in one direction: all T for the rows, all L for the columns. But most terms are mixed, and a mixed term is expensive in both directions. Even if each term goes to its cheaper direction, the terms with $|J| \approx t/2$ cost about 2^t each, and there are about 2^t of them:

$$\frac{4^t}{2t+2} \;\le\; \sum_{J} 4^{\min(|J|,\, t-|J|)} \;\le\; 4^t.$$

This is smaller than the $4^t = 2^{2t}$ values of the $2t$ diagonal bits only by a factor polynomial in t: no exponential improvement.

5.2 Two Identities

Goal. For the rows, L is expensive (row rank 4) and T is cheap (row rank 1). We want to replace L by something cheaper, and pay only with factors T. For the columns, the roles of L and T are exchanged.

Gram–Schmidt. Take the inner product $\langle \varphi, \psi \rangle = \sum_{x,y,u,v} \varphi\, \psi$. Then $\langle L, L \rangle = \langle T, T \rangle = 4$ and $\langle L, T \rangle = 2$. Make L orthogonal to T, and T orthogonal to L:

$$\mu = L - \frac{\langle L, T \rangle}{\langle T, T \rangle}\, T = L - \tfrac{1}{2} T, \qquad \nu = T - \frac{\langle T, L \rangle}{\langle L, L \rangle}\, L = T - \tfrac{1}{2} L.$$

So $L = \mu + \frac{1}{2} T$ and $T = \nu + \frac{1}{2} L$.

The claim. μ has row rank 3, and ν has column rank 3.

Proof. We use the matrices of Section 4.3.

- Rows: $L = I$ and $T = \beta\beta^{\mathsf{T}}$, so

  $$\mu = I - \tfrac{1}{2}\beta\beta^{\mathsf{T}} = I - \frac{\beta\beta^{\mathsf{T}}}{|\beta|^2}$$

  is the projection onto the vectors orthogonal to β. It has rank 3.

- Columns: $T = P$ and $L = \gamma\gamma^{\mathsf{T}}$. Since $P\gamma = \gamma$,

  $$\nu = P - \tfrac{1}{2}\gamma\gamma^{\mathsf{T}} = P\Big(I - \frac{\gamma\gamma^{\mathsf{T}}}{|\gamma|^2}\Big)$$

  is the invertible matrix P times the projection onto the vectors orthogonal to γ. It has rank 3.

5.3 Split by Majority

Using μ for all of q does not help: $q = \prod_j (\mu_j - \frac{1}{2} T_j)$ still has row rank 4^t: multiplied out, it is $(3+1)^t$ products, and the terms with many μ are expensive. So send each term to its majority: a term with more T than L goes to the rows, and the others go to the columns,

$$q = \underbrace{\sum_{|J| > t/2} (-1)^{|J|}\, T_J\, L_{\bar{J}}}_{q^+\text{: rows}} + \underbrace{\sum_{|J| \le t/2} (-1)^{|J|}\, T_J\, L_{\bar{J}}}_{q^-\text{: columns}}.$$

Theorem 3 (Splitting a crossing)**.** *q^+ has row rank at most $(2\sqrt{3})^t$, and q^- has column rank at most $(2\sqrt{3})^t$.*

Proof. We use two facts about ranks: the rank of a sum is at most the sum of the ranks, and ranks multiply over the bits. For a set K of bits, write $\mu_{\bar{K}} = \prod_{j\notin K} \mu_j$ and $\nu_{\bar{K}} = \prod_{j\notin K} \nu_j$.

The rows: q^+. Replace every L_j by $\mu_j + \frac{1}{2}T_j$:

$$q^+ = \sum_{|J|>t/2} (-1)^{|J|}\, T_J \prod_{j\notin J} \big(\mu_j + \tfrac{1}{2}T_j\big).$$

Multiply out the product. Each bit $j \notin J$ gives either μ_j or $\frac{1}{2}T_j$, so there is one term for each set $A \subseteq \bar{J}$ of the bits that give $\frac{1}{2}T_j$:

$$T_J \prod_{j\notin J} \big(\mu_j + \tfrac{1}{2}T_j\big) = \sum_{A\subseteq \bar{J}} 2^{-|A|}\, T_{J\cup A}\, \mu_{\overline{J\cup A}}.$$

Each term has T at the bits of $K = J \cup A$ and μ at the other bits. Collect the terms with the same K. For them $|A| = |K| - |J|$ and $|K| \geq |J| > t/2$, so

$$q^+ = \sum_{|K|>t/2} c_K\, T_K\, \mu_{\bar{K}}, \qquad c_K = \sum_{J\subseteq K,\ |J|>t/2} (-1)^{|J|}\, 2^{|J|-|K|}.$$

Then

$$\text{row rank of } q^+ \ \leq \sum_{|K|>t/2} \underbrace{1}_{T_K} \cdot \underbrace{3^{t-|K|}}_{\mu_{\bar{K}}} \leq \underbrace{2^t}_{\text{sets } K} \cdot 3^{t/2} = (2\sqrt{3})^t.$$

The columns: q^-. Similarly, with L and T exchanged: replace every T_j by $\nu_j + \frac{1}{2}L_j$. This gives $q^- = \sum_{|K|\geq t/2} c'_K\, L_K\, \nu_{\bar{K}}$ for some numbers c'_K, so q^- has column rank at most $(2\sqrt{3})^t$. □

6 The Algorithm

6.1 Merging Many Rectangles at Once

There are $\binom{\sqrt{G}}{2}^2$ rectangles. Every D variable is now two copies, and the crossing q_ρ of a rectangle ρ checks that its copies agree (Section 4). So

$$Z(\mathcal{N}) = \sum_{R,\,C,\,\text{copies}} \prod_g Z_g \prod_\rho q_\rho.$$

Put $q_\rho = q_\rho^+ + q_\rho^-$ (Theorem 3) and multiply out the product over ρ. This gives one term for each choice of a sign $\sigma(\rho) \in \{+,-\}$ for every rectangle ρ:

$$Z(\mathcal{N}) = \sum_\sigma Z(\mathcal{N}^\sigma), \qquad Z(\mathcal{N}^\sigma) = \sum_{R,C,\text{copies}} \prod_g Z_g \prod_\rho q_\rho^{\sigma(\rho)}.$$

These are $2^{\binom{\sqrt{G}}{2}^2}$ networks, a constant number, and we compute each of them separately. Each $\mathcal{N}^\sigma$ votes: if $\sigma(\rho) = +$ for at least half of the rectangles, it is merged by rows; otherwise, by columns.

The run time.

Take $\mathcal{N}^\sigma$ merged by rows. Before the split, each rectangle has its $2t$ diagonal bits in the outer sum: 2^{2t} values. After it,

$$\begin{aligned} &\text{type } + : \quad (2\sqrt{3})^t = 2^{2t} \cdot \left(\tfrac{\sqrt{3}}{2}\right)^t \text{ values (the choice of a product } f\,h), \\ &\text{type } - : \quad 2^{2t} \text{ values, as before.} \end{aligned}$$

By the vote, at least half of the rectangles have type $+$, so on average each rectangle gains at least the geometric mean $\left(\tfrac{\sqrt{3}}{2}\right)^{t/2}$, that is $\left(\tfrac{\sqrt{3}}{2}\right)^{1/4}$ for each of its $2t$ diagonal bits. The diagonal bits are the D variables, a fraction $\frac{\sqrt{G}-1}{\sqrt{G}+1}$ of the N shared variables (Section 3). So the number of values in the outer sum is

$$\begin{aligned} &\text{before the split:} \quad 2^N, \\ &\text{after the split:} \quad 2^{(1-\eta)N}, \qquad \eta = \frac{\sqrt{G}-1}{\sqrt{G}+1} \cdot \frac{1}{4} \log_2 \frac{2}{\sqrt{3}} \approx \frac{1}{2} - \frac{1}{4}\log_2(2\sqrt{3}) \approx 0.05. \end{aligned}$$

6.2 Recursion

A merge takes G groups to $\sqrt{G}$ groups, and then we can merge again. Let Q be the number of groups at the end and ℓ the number of merges, and start with $G = Q^{2^\ell}$ groups:

$$G = Q^{2^\ell} \;\to\; Q^{2^{\ell-1}} \;\to\; \cdots \;\to\; Q^2 \;\to\; Q.$$

Every level has at least Q^2 groups, and Q is large, so $\eta \approx \frac{1}{2} - \frac{1}{4}\log_2(2\sqrt{3})$ at every level. So after ℓ merges the outer sums keep at most $(1-\eta)^\ell N + O(1)$ bits. Take ℓ large enough that

$$(1-\eta)^\ell N + O(1) \;\le\; \frac{\delta n}{4}.$$

Such an ℓ depends only on k and δ: every variable has fewer copies than clauses that contain it, so $N \le km$, and $m = O_{k,\delta}(n)$ by Section 2.1. Then choose Q so large that the inside cost of the Q final groups, $2^{O_k(n/Q)}$, is at most $2^{\delta n/4}$. Altogether, the running time is

$$\underbrace{2^{\delta n/2}}_{\text{formulas in } \mathcal{L}} \cdot \underbrace{O_{k,\delta}(1)}_{\text{networks } \mathcal{N}^\sigma} \cdot \underbrace{2^{\delta n/4}}_{\text{outer sums}} \cdot \underbrace{2^{\delta n/4}}_{\text{inside the } Q \text{ groups}} = O_{k,\delta}\big(2^{\delta n}\big),$$

plus $2^{\delta n/2}\,\mathrm{poly}(n)$ to compute $\mathcal{L}$ (Section 2.1).

A Proof of the Sparsification Lemma

A.1 The Algorithm

Key idea: for all $\kappa < s$, find a sub-clause H with κ literals that is contained in ***many*** s-clauses of F, and split into two cases. Let $S \subseteq F$ be the s-clauses that contain H.

- If H is true, every clause of S is true: replace them all by the one clause H.
- If H is false, every literal of H is false: add the 1-clauses $\{\neg\ell\}$, $\ell \in H$, and remove H from each clause of S.

This gives the two formulas

$$F_1 = (F \setminus S) \cup \{H\}, \qquad F_2 = (F \setminus S) \cup \{\, C \setminus H : C \in S \,\} \cup \{\, \{\neg\ell\} : \ell \in H \,\}.$$

Lemma 4 (Disjoint branches, as in [6, Lemma A.1])**.** *Every assignment that satisfies F satisfies exactly one of F_1 and F_2, and every assignment that satisfies F_1 or F_2 satisfies F. So $Z(F) = Z(F_1) + Z(F_2)$. Also,* Dedup *(below) keeps the satisfying assignments of every formula; so $Z(\textsc{Dedup}(F)) = Z(F)$, and the above holds after* Dedup *is applied to F, F_1 and F_2.*

Proof. An assignment that satisfies F_1 makes H true, and one that satisfies F_2 makes every literal of H false; so no assignment satisfies both. Let α satisfy F. If α satisfies H, it satisfies F_1. If not, every literal of H is false under α, so α satisfies each $\{\neg\ell\}$, and for each $C \in S$ a literal of $C \setminus H$ is true; thus α satisfies F_2. Conversely, $H \subseteq C$ and $C \setminus H \subseteq C$ for every $C \in S$, so an assignment that satisfies F_1 or F_2 satisfies every clause of S, and hence F. Finally, Dedup removes only clauses that contain another clause of the formula; such a clause is true whenever the smaller one is, so Dedup keeps the satisfying assignments. □

Example 2. Let $F = (x \vee y \vee a) \wedge (x \vee y \vee b) \wedge (x \vee y \vee c) \wedge (x \vee d \vee e)$, let $H = x \vee y$, and let S be the first three clauses. Then

$$F_1 = (x \vee y) \wedge (x \vee d \vee e), \qquad F_2 = (\neg x) \wedge (\neg y) \wedge (a) \wedge (b) \wedge (c) \wedge (x \vee d \vee e).$$

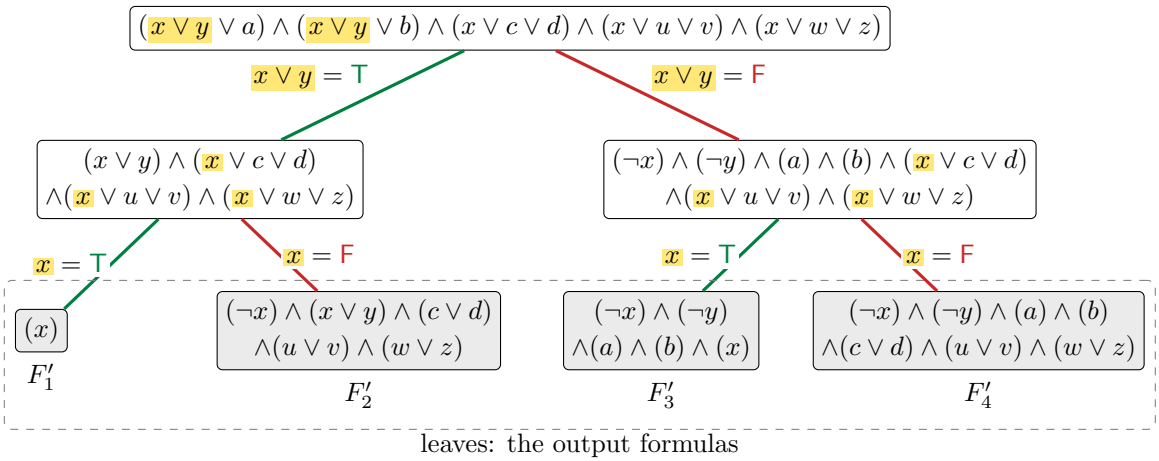
In F_1 three 3-clauses became one 2-clause; in F_2 they became three 1-clauses, and F_2 also has the 1-clauses $\neg x$ and $\neg y$.

Fix thresholds $\theta_1, \dots, \theta_{k-1}$; Section A.3 chooses them. For a formula F, let

$$\textsc{Dedup}(F) = \{\, C \in F : \text{no } D \in F \text{ with } D \subsetneq C \,\}.$$

Sparsification. $\textsc{Sparsify}(F)$, for a k-CNF formula F.

```
F ← Dedup(F)
for s = 2, ..., k do                                   ▷ shortest clauses first
    for κ = s − 1, ..., 1 do                           ▷ largest sets first
        H ← a set of κ literals in the most s-clauses of F
        S ← { C ∈ F : |C| = s,  H ⊆ C }
        if |S| ≥ θ_{s−κ} then
            F_1 ← Dedup(F ∪ {H})                       ▷ H = T
            F_2 ← Dedup(F ∪ { C \ H : C ∈ S } ∪ { {¬ℓ} : ℓ ∈ H })   ▷ H = F
            return Sparsify(F_1) ∪ Sparsify(F_2)
        end if
    end for
end for
return {F}                                             ▷ no set is in many clauses
```



$$Z(F) = Z(F'_1) + Z(F'_2) + Z(F'_3) + Z(F'_4)$$

Figure 6: The recursive calls of the sparsification algorithm ($\theta_1 = 2$, $\theta_2 = 3$).

A.2 Analysis

Let $\varepsilon > 0$. A list for a smaller ε also satisfies Lemma 2 for ε, so we may assume that ε is small enough in terms of k. We prove that there are thresholds $\theta_1(\varepsilon), \dots, \theta_{k-1}(\varepsilon)$ such that every leaf formula has at most $M(\varepsilon)\, n$ clauses and there are at most $2^{\varepsilon n}$ leaves.

Claim 5 (Small formulas)**.** *Every leaf formula has at most Mn clauses, where*

$$M = M(k, \varepsilon) = O(1 + \theta_1 + \cdots + \theta_{k-1}).$$

Proof. At a leaf F', every literal is in fewer than θ_{s-1} s-clauses, otherwise the recursion would split F'. Count the pairs (literal ℓ, s-clause that contains ℓ): each s-clause is in s pairs, and each of the $2n$ literals is in fewer than θ_{s-1}, so

$$s \cdot \#s\text{-clauses} \;<\; 2n\,\theta_{s-1}.$$

With $\#1$-clauses $\leq 2n$, this gives

$$|F'| = \sum_{s=1}^{k} \#s\text{-clauses} = O\big(1 + \theta_1 + \cdots + \theta_{k-1}\big)\, n. \qquad \square$$

Claim 6 (Few leaves)**.** *The tree has at most $2^{\varepsilon n}$ leaves.*

Fix a path from the root to a leaf. A split happens in the algorithm at some values of s and κ: H has κ literals and S is a set of s-clauses. We call it a split *on size s*. It *adds* H (case $H = \mathsf{T}$, a green edge in Figure 6), or the clauses $C \setminus H$, $C \in S$, and the 1-clauses $\{\neg\ell\}$, $\ell \in H$ (case $H = \mathsf{F}$, a red edge); these have κ, $s - \kappa$ and 1 literals, all fewer than s. A clause that is already in the formula is not added. Let A_r be the number of r-clauses added on the path.

Lemma 7 (The order)**.** *Let $1 \leq j < r \leq k$. After the first split on a size larger than r, every set J of j literals is always inside fewer than $2\theta_{r-j}$ r-clauses.*

Proof. Only splits on sizes $s > r$ add r-clauses, so between two such splits the number of r-clauses that contain J can only go down. So it is enough to look at one split on a size $s > r$, with a sub-clause H of κ literals, and to show two things.

1. *Before the split, J is in fewer than θ_{r-j} r-clauses.* The algorithm tested the r-clauses before the s-clauses, and found no set of j literals in θ_{r-j} or more of them.
2. *The split adds at most θ_{r-j} r-clauses that contain J.*
   (a) Case $H = \mathsf{T}$: the split adds one clause.
   (b) Case $H = \mathsf{F}$: a new r-clause $C \setminus H$ (so $s - \kappa = r$) that contains J comes from an s-clause $C \supseteq H \cup J$. The algorithm tested the larger set $H \cup J$ before H, so fewer than $\theta_{s-\kappa-j} = \theta_{r-j}$ s-clauses contain it.

Together, J is in fewer than $2\theta_{r-j}$ r-clauses after the split. $\square$

Proposition 8 (Few short clauses)**.** *For $s = 1, \dots, k-1$ there is a number b_s, which is a function of $\theta_1, \dots, \theta_{s-1}$ only, such that $A_s \le b_s n$ on every path.*

Proof. By induction on s.

Base case. $A_1 \le 2n$, so $b_1 = 2$: there are $2n$ 1-clauses, and DEDUP never removes a 1-clause, so each of them is added at most once.

Step, $s \ge 2$. An added s-clause is in the leaf formula, or it was removed. So

$$A_s \le (s\text{-clauses in the leaf}) + (\text{added } s\text{-clauses that were removed}).$$

In the leaf there are fewer than $\theta_{s-1} n$ s-clauses (proof of Claim 5). DEDUP removes an s-clause only when a clause D strictly inside it is added, with $|D| = j < s$. The s-clause was added at a split on a size larger than s, so by Lemma 7 with $r = s$, D is inside fewer than $2\theta_{s-j}$ s-clauses when it is added. So

$$A_s \le \theta_{s-1} n + 2 \sum_{j=1}^{s-1} \theta_{s-j} A_j \le \underbrace{\left(\theta_{s-1} + 2 \sum_{j=1}^{s-1} \theta_{s-j} b_j\right)}_{b_s} n,$$

and b_s is a function of $\theta_1, \dots, \theta_{s-1}$, because each b_j with $j < s$ is. □

A.3 Thresholds and the Number of Leaves

Since b_s is a function of $\theta_1, \dots, \theta_{s-1}$, we can choose the thresholds one at a time:

$$\theta_s = \lceil b_s / \varepsilon^2 \rceil \qquad (s = 1, \dots, k-1).$$

Size of b_s. Since $b_j \ge 1 \ge \varepsilon^2$, we have $\theta_j = O(b_j/\varepsilon^2)$. For $s \ge 2$, b_s is a sum of $O(k)$ terms, and each of them is $O(b_{s-j} b_j / \varepsilon^2)$ for some $1 \le j < s$ (for the term θ_{s-1}, because $b_1 \ge 1$); so $b_s \le O(k/\varepsilon^2) \max_{1 \le j < s} b_{s-j} b_j$. By induction on s, with the same constant in O at every step, taken at least 1, $b_s \le O(k/\varepsilon^2)^{2s-1} = (k/\varepsilon)^{O(s)}$. So $b = b_1 + \cdots + b_{k-1} \le (k/\varepsilon)^{O(k)}$.

Proof of Claim 6 (Few leaves). Fix a path from the root to a leaf.

- *Splits.* Each split adds at least one clause with fewer than k literals, so the path has at most $A_1 + \cdots + A_{k-1} \le bn$ splits.
- *Red edges.* A red edge whose split adds clauses $C \setminus H$ with s literals adds at least θ_s of them (one clause $C \setminus H$ for each $C \in S$), and all the splits together add at most $A_s \le b_s n$ s-clauses. So there are at most $b_s n / \theta_s \le \varepsilon^2 n$ such red edges, and at most $(k-1)\varepsilon^2 n \le k\varepsilon^2 n$ red edges in all.

So a path is a string over $\{\mathsf{T}, \mathsf{F}\}$ (one letter for each split: T for a green edge, F for a red edge) of length at most bn with at most $k\varepsilon^2 n$ letters F. Different leaves give different strings, because their paths separate at a split where one takes T and the other F; so we may pad every string with T's to length exactly $\lfloor bn \rfloor$. Hence

$$\#\text{leaves} \;\le\; \sum_{i \le k\varepsilon^2 n} \binom{\lfloor bn \rfloor}{i} \;\le\; \left(\frac{eb}{k\varepsilon^2}\right)^{k\varepsilon^2 n} \;=\; 2^{\,k\varepsilon^2 \log_2(eb/(k\varepsilon^2))\, n}.$$

Here

$$k\varepsilon^2 \log_2\big(eb/(k\varepsilon^2)\big) = k\varepsilon^2 \cdot O\big(k \log(k/\varepsilon)\big) = \varepsilon \cdot O\big(k^2 \varepsilon \log(k/\varepsilon)\big) \le \varepsilon,$$

because ε is small enough in terms of k. So the tree has at most $2^{\varepsilon n}$ leaves. □

Claim 9 (Time)**.** *The algorithm runs in time* $2^{\varepsilon n}\mathrm{poly}_{k,\varepsilon}(n)$.

Proof. A formula has $n^{O(k)}$ clauses, so one call takes time $\mathrm{poly}_k(n)$, not counting its recursive calls. Every node is on a path from the root to a leaf, and a path has at most $bn + 1$ nodes, so the tree has at most $(bn + 1) \cdot 2^{\varepsilon n}$ nodes. □

A.4 Proof of the Lemma

Proof of Lemma 2. We run Sparsify on F, with the thresholds of Section A.3, and we take for $\mathcal{L}$ the set of leaf formulas. Every clause that the algorithm adds has at most k literals on the same n variables, so every formula in $\mathcal{L}$ is a k-CNF formula on the same n variables. We now check the three properties and the time.

(a) By Claim 6, the tree has at most $2^{\varepsilon n}$ leaves, so $\mathcal{L}$ has at most $2^{\varepsilon n}$ formulas.

(b) By Claim 5, every leaf formula has at most Mn clauses.

(c) By Lemma 4, Dedup keeps the satisfying assignments, and at each split every assignment that satisfies the formula satisfies exactly one of F_1 and F_2, while every assignment that satisfies F_1 or F_2 satisfies the formula. Going from the root down to the leaves, every assignment that satisfies F satisfies exactly one formula in $\mathcal{L}$, and every assignment that satisfies a formula in $\mathcal{L}$ satisfies F.

Time. By Claim 9, the algorithm runs in time $2^{\varepsilon n}\mathrm{poly}_{k,\varepsilon}(n)$. □

B The Balancing Lemma

Lemma 10 (Balancing [4, Lemma C.3])**.** *For $r \geq 1$, $\varepsilon > 0$ and $g \geq g_0(r, \varepsilon)$: if every two of g^2 groups share between w and rw bits, they can be placed in a $g \times g$ grid in which, for some μ, μ', every two rows share $(1 \pm \varepsilon)\mu$ bits and every two columns share $(1 \pm \varepsilon)\mu'$ bits.*

Proof. Permute each column of a grid by an independent random permutation. The distribution is invariant under permutations of the rows, so the bits shared by two rows have the same mean $\mu \geq g^2 w$ for all pairs, and changing one permutation changes them by at most $2grw$. By McDiarmid's inequality [12], they are outside $(1 \pm \varepsilon)\mu$ with probability $e^{-\Omega(\varepsilon^2 g / r^2)} < g^{-2}$. Fix permutations that work for all pairs of rows, and then permute inside each row in the same way, which keeps the rows. □

References

[1] B. Bollobás, A. D. Scott. Judicious partitions of bounded-degree graphs. *J. Graph Theory* 46(2):131–143, 2004.

[2] C. Calabro, R. Impagliazzo, R. Paturi. A duality between clause width and clause density for SAT. *Proc. 21st IEEE Conference on Computational Complexity*, pages 252–260, 2006.

[3] C. Calabro, R. Impagliazzo, R. Paturi. The complexity of satisfiability of small depth circuits. *Proc. 4th International Workshop on Parameterized and Exact Computation*, LNCS 5917, pages 75–85, 2009.

[4] Claude (Anthropic). A $2^{o(n)}$ time algorithm for 3-SAT. Anthropic manuscript, October 26, 2026.

[5] V. Dahllöf, P. Jonsson, M. Wahlström. Counting models for 2SAT and 3SAT formulae. *Theoretical Computer Science* 332(1–3):265–291, 2005.

[6] H. Dell, T. Husfeldt, D. Marx, N. Taslaman, M. Wahlén. Exponential time complexity of the permanent and the Tutte polynomial. *ACM Transactions on Algorithms* 10(4), Article 21, 2014.

[7] O. Dubois. Counting the number of solutions for instances of satisfiability. *Theoretical Computer Science* 81(1):49–64, 1991.

[8] T. Hertli. 3-SAT faster and simpler—Unique-SAT bounds for PPSZ hold in general. *SIAM J. Computing* 43(2):718–729, 2014.

[9] R. Impagliazzo, R. Paturi. On the complexity of k-SAT. *J. Computer and System Sciences* 62(2):367–375, 2001.

[10] R. Impagliazzo, R. Paturi, F. Zane. Which problems have strongly exponential complexity? *J. Computer and System Sciences* 63(4):512–530, 2001.

[11] D. Lokshtanov, D. Marx, S. Saurabh. Lower bounds based on the Exponential Time Hypothesis. *Bulletin of the EATCS* 105:41–72, 2011.

[12] C. McDiarmid. On the method of bounded differences. In *Surveys in Combinatorics 1989*, London Math. Soc. Lecture Note Series 141, pages 148–188. Cambridge University Press, 1989.

[13] B. Monien, E. Speckenmeyer. Solving satisfiability in less than 2^n steps. *Discrete Applied Mathematics* 10(3):287–295, 1985.

[14] R. Paturi, P. Pudlák, M. E. Saks, F. Zane. An improved exponential-time algorithm for k-SAT. *J. ACM* 52(3):337–364, 2005.

[15] M. Samer, S. Szeider. Algorithms for propositional model counting. *J. Discrete Algorithms* 8(1):50–64, 2010.

[16] U. Schöning. A probabilistic algorithm for k-SAT and constraint satisfaction problems. *Proc. 40th IEEE Symposium on Foundations of Computer Science*, pages 410–414, 1999.